

The post-World War One period was said to have produced a confused, insecure and disillusioned Lost Generation. There is, tragically enough, ample evidence to indicate that the post-World War Two era produced a generation which has, in large part, lost its sense of perspective and purpose. It is a generation whose members are prone to substitute flimsy dollars-and-cents price tags for scales of lasting values and who meekly surrender their individuality and even their integrity as human beings. A glaringly obvious manifestation of this can be found in the social phenomenon of status seeking, which has become so widespread and prevalent that it looms as one of the principle motivating forces behind our contemporary social behavior patterns.

Now, I agree that the desire of human beings to rise above the mass and to gain the respect of their fellow men is a basic one. Within certain broad limits and subject to certain self-evident reservations, it is a constructive and salutary motivation. The desire to excel has impelled countless individuals to make important contributions to the progress of civilization. But, as more than one observer has noted, the rationale of today's status seeking and the directions it takes are neither constructive nor healthy.

To my way of thinking, status may be defined as a form of recognition an individual's peers award him for above-average contributions to society. It is something that must be earned, a reward for accomplishment that is awarded at a degree proportionate to the value or importance of what

263

the individual contributes toward the common good.

Nowadays, however, the tendency is to equate status almost automatically—and all but exclusively—with financial success. And, it seems that the achievement of status not only is, per se, considered an end unto itself, but that for many it has become the sole motivation and the only worthwhile goal.

Vast numbers of people have apparently convinced themselves that the amassing of money and the material things it can buy alone signifies achievement, connotes success and confers status. They pile up money and